Each House of Parliament has separate secretarial staff of its own, though there can be some posts common to both the Houses. Their recruitment and service conditions are regulated by Parliament. The secretariat of each House is headed by a secretary-general. He/she is a permanent officer and is appointed by the presiding officer of the House.

LEADERS IN PARLIAMENT



Leader of the House

Under the Rules of Lok Sabha, the 'Leader of the House' means the prime minister, if he/she is a member of the Lok Sabha, or a minister who is a member of the Lok Sabha and is nominated by the prime minister to function as the Leader of the House. There is also a 'Leader of the House' in the Rajya Sabha. He/she is a minister and a member of the Rajya Sabha and is nominated by the prime minister to function as such. The leader of the house in either House is an important functionary and exercises direct influence on the conduct of business. He/she can also nominate a deputy leader of the House. The same functionary in USA is known as the 'majority leader'.



Leader of the Opposition

In each House of Parliament, there is the 'Leader of the Opposition'. In a parliamentary system of government, the leader of the opposition has a significant role to play. His/her main functions are to provide a constructive criticism of the policies of the government and to provide an alternative government. Therefore, the leaders of Opposition in the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha were accorded statutory recognition in 1977 under the Salary and Allowances of Leaders of Opposition in Parliament Act, 1977. They are also entitled to the salary, allowances and other facilities equivalent to that of a cabinet minister. It was in 1969 that an official leader of the opposition was recognised for the first time. The same functionary in USA is known as the 'minority leader'.

Under the above Act, the 'Leader of the Opposition' means that member of the Rajya Sabha or the Lok Sabha who is, for the time being, the Leader in that House of the party in opposition to the government having the greatest numerical strength and recognised as such by the Chairman or the Speaker. Further, where there are two or more parties in opposition to the government having the same numerical strength, the Chairman or the Speaker shall (having regard to the status of the parties) recognise any one of the Leaders of such parties as the Leader of the Opposition and such recognition shall be final and conclusive. According to the directions issued by both the Chairman and the Speaker, the minimum numerical strength required for recognition as a political party is one-tenth of the total membership of that House.

The British political system has an unique institution called the 'Shadow Cabinet'. It is formed by the Opposition party to balance the ruling cabinet and to prepare its members for future ministerial offices. In this shadow cabinet, almost every member in the ruling cabinet is 'shadowed' by a corresponding member in the opposition cabinet. This shadow cabinet serves as the 'alternate cabinet' if there is change of government. That is why Ivor Jennings described the leader of Opposition as the 'alternative Prime Minister'. He/she enjoys the status of a minister and is paid by the government.